

13 'Environmental Heroes' working to protect the Earth

The Earth Coalition of Charlotte-Mecklenburg honored 13 people for helping the environment and named them "Environmental Heroes" on Earth Day last month. This is how the Earth Coalition describes their contributions:

• **Oren McCullough** — McCullough, a retired mail carrier, recycles paper and cleans up his west Charlotte neighborhood. He picks up glass from neighborhood businesses, even off the street, and donates the proceeds to the West Charlotte Lions Club.

• **Tecil Curlee** — Curlee is always picking up litter, plastic bottles, glass and cans. He has been composting for more than 35 years. He donated his aluminum recycling proceeds to the Humane Society of Charlotte. Whenever possible, Curlee rides his bike or walks rather than drives.

• **Deborah Sue Griffin** — Griffin was instrumental in starting the Carolina Raptor Center and has continued her work there over the years. She has been a guest speaker, conducting educational programs for adults and children, at the Environmental Education Center at Camp Thunderbird.

• **Water Woman (Lorraine Loken)** — Sponsored by the Charlotte-Mecklenburg Utility Department, Loken created the Water Woman character. Water Woman (sometimes played by other people) has visited more than 2,000 schoolchildren and made them "Hydro Heroes." She teaches about the water cycle and how to protect and conserve drinking water.

• **Ramsey Penegar** — Ramsey is an eighth-grade student who is collecting signatures to rid the Gaston County public school cafeterias of plastic foam. She refuses takeout orders served in plastic foam containers and sends them back to be wrapped in wax paper or foil. She polices her family's trash to check for recyclable items tossed out by mistake.

• **Thomas H. Huggins** — Huggins, a member of the Lake Norman Yacht Club, has been instrumental in encouraging the proper disposal of plastic foam dock flotation materials and pressure-treated wood. He developed a plan to have trees downed by Hugo trans-



McCullough



Curlee



Griffin



Loken



Horton



Drum



Hubbard



Malakoff

ported to a paper mill instead of a landfill. He also coordinates a can recycling program.

• **Dr. Jim Horton** — Horton, chairman of the Mecklenburg County Environmental Protection Commission, pushed for the Mountain Island Lake watershed protection program. And his efforts have resulted in progress toward controlling toxic air emissions, with the adoption of a county ordinance regulating infectious waste incinerators.

• **Sierra Club Inner City Outings (ICO) program** — **David Drum, Debbie Hubbard, Mara Malakoff** — Under their leadership, the Charlotte ICO program conducted more than 45 programs last year for more than 300 youngsters. The program cultivates a love of nature in those who normally would not have a chance to experience it, through camping, hiking, canoeing, nature games, educational events and service outings.

• **Douglas Edward Simpson** — Simpson started recycling aluminum cans at work. That snowballed into a large program when other departments started bringing him their cans. He spends up to eight hours a week sorting cans and taking them to the recycling center. The Humane Society of Union County has received \$200 to



Collins



Alexander

\$250 from his recycling efforts.

• **Scott Collins** — Collins is the recycling coordinator for UNC Charlotte. Originally, he wanted to develop a recycling program for his dorm, and now he supervises the campuswide program. Through his efforts, UNCC has reduced its aluminum can trash by 44%, or 4 tons, in a year. He was named Mecklenburg's outstanding individual recycler for 1990.

• **Roy Alexander** — Alexander, as co-founder of the Metrolina Environmental Concern Association, ran the first citizens recycling center in the region. He served on the first study group for recycling in Charlotte and has been instrumental in coordinating more than 300 workshops, field trips and learning vacations with Science Museums of Charlotte.